



SLIGHTLY SHUFFLED SOUTHERN SOLID FOR '56

By BOB CHRISTIAN

Atlanta Journal-Constitution Staff Writer

JACKSONVILLE, Fla., March 10—The Southern Assn. avoided realignment but did not escape a number of intra-league changes during the winter.

While other circuits were troubled with franchise changes or the threat of a complete foldup, the Class AA Southern undertook to strengthen its own clubs.

Dividends from the new projects remain to be seen but the league has plunged into spring training with the usual enthusiasm emitted after the first crack of a bat.

The changes deal with an ownership swap, a shift in a working agreement, return of an old established front office executive and a decision to fight the battle as an independent club.

THE OWNERSHIP change is in Memphis, where a group of eager baseball enthusiasts are shooting for the attendance trophy as well as a pennant. Mobile underwent an enforced working agreement swap, moving into the Cleveland organization when Brooklyn discontinued its Southern Assn. affiliate.

Little Rock, a risk even when serving as Detroit's farm, has, decided upon an independent operation

with old-timer Ray Winder still in the driver's seat. And Vince Rizzo is the "old friend" back in the league.

Rizzo, a member of the New Orleans staff several years ago, returns to take over the Pelicans' reins, removing the fanfare and conversation which characterized the operation in '55. He and Andy Cohen, who returns as manager, should make one of the best combinations in the league.

Memphis is the spot that will be watched keenly. After a long and fairly successful Chicago-owned-and-operated club, the Chicks now are in the hands of free-spending Nat Buring. He has been throwing money around with reckless abandon—shooting for double or nothing.

His reconditioning of Russwood Park, a worthwhile project, already has reached the \$150,000 mark. New clubhouses and a new press box have been built; a \$27,000 scoreboard has been erected; turnstiles that click with the insertion of a silver dollar have been installed and the park in general has been given a badly needed face-lifting.

IN CONTRAST to the 1955 season when seven new skippers came into the league, the 1956 campaign will open with only two new managers. They are Jo Jo White, a native Georgian who was handpicked by Cleveland to skipper Mobile, and Ernie White, one-time St. Louis Cardinal pitching star, who moves into Nashville.

Jo Jo White succeeds Clay Bryant, who guided the Bears to a Dixie Series championship. Bryant was moved by Brooklyn to its Fort Worth club of the Class AA Texas League.

Ernie White's going to Nashville means a reunion with old general manager, Bill McCarthy. They rated tops in the South Atlantic League when they directed Columbia, S.C.

Skippers returning are: Cal Ermer, dean of the league who is returning for an unprecedented term at Chattanooga; Cohen at New Orleans; the affable Phil Page, Birmingham; Steve Souchock, Little Rock; Jack Cassini, Peck's Bad Boy, Memphis, and Clyde King, Atlanta.

King and Souchock were midseason picks last year, replacing George McQuinn and Bobby Mavis respectively.

Each club has its problems in player personnel until major league and AAA clubs reduce their rosters. But there are a number of old faces returning—including ex-Cracker Country Brown, now in Nashville; pitcher Al Sima, Chattanooga; Nashville third baseman Tommy Brown; Little Rock's forever R. C. Otey; New Orleans pitcher Lenny Yochim, a Crescent City showboat, and probably a dozen more.

Managers refrain from going out on the limb to pick top rookies in March. Most of them are Class D, C, and B graduates and many of them will return to their alma maters when pitchers start to throw curve balls.